



HITTING THE RIGHT NOTE
Clockwise from above, Usha Uthup at an 'Ibtida - Ek Mehfil' programme in Delhi; a Tales Of A City mehfil; a Baithak Foundation gathering in Pune

gence of baithaks in the country and that gave us an opportunity to work in this space," explains Manish Saksena, lead advisor for Aadyam Handwoven, a corporate social enterprise working with weaver communities. He has organised and co-curated many baithaks with prominent artists that have showcased their products in their natural environment—sometimes worn by the performer and key guests and sometimes used in the setup.

Apart from the décor, baithak etiquette forms an integral part of the experience—reaching on time, adhering to the dress code, keeping the phones switched off and not eating during the performance. With so much going for it, the baithak culture is undoubtedly here to stay, although how it evolves remains to be seen. ■

–Anubhuti Krishna

Duo Lingo

Music composer pair **Naren Chandavarkar** and **Benedict Taylor** have managed to make their long-distance collaboration work

If you're a fan of screenwriters such as Sudip Sharma (*Paatal Lok, Kohrra*) or directors like Abhishek Chaubey (*Udta Punjab, Killer Soup*), Avinash Arun (*Killa, Unpaused*) and Amit Masurkar (*Newton, Sherni*), then you've heard the work of Naren-Benedict. Each of them counts the composer duo of Mumbai-residing Naren Chandavarkar and London-based Benedict Taylor as regular collaborators.

The pair, whose latest is the music for *Paatal Lok 2*, believes they've established a comfort zone with these filmmakers. "With creative areas where things can be quite abstract, you end up going back to the same people who you can really trust and have a creative shorthand with," says Chandavarkar, whose Marathi drama *Sabar Bonda (Cactus Pears)*, in which he's both co-producer and sound designer, recently won the World Cinema Grand Jury Prize at the Sundance Film Festival. "At the root of it is that you get along," adds Taylor.

He was introduced to Chandavarkar in 2007 by a mutual friend. At the time, Taylor was teaching viola at the Mehli Mehta Music Foundation in Mumbai and Chandavarkar was an actor with The Company Theatre. "We formed a very quick friendship," says Chandavarkar. "We liked the same books, movies and music."

When Anurag Kashyap asked him to score his film *That Girl in Yellow Boots* in 2009, he couldn't "think of anyone else" to team up with. Taylor had moved back to the UK by then, but Chandavarkar and he soon mastered the art of collaborating remotely. Taylor also visits Mumbai, where they have their studio called Moonweave, every few months.

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Over the past decade and a half, they've composed for productions of widely varying scales, from the indie Marathi movie *Killa* to Sanjay Leela Bhansali's grand spectacle *Heeramandi*. Upcoming releases include the second season of *Kohrra* and the Bengali movie *Baksho Bondi (Shadowbox)*, which will premiere at the Berlin International Film Festival this month.

Though their credits list might be short on rom-coms, they say they're "open to any kind of genre". While Taylor prefers "heavy arthouse projects", Chandavarkar says if at all he has a wishlist, it's for an assignment where "you can really push the envelope, but you're also afforded the luxury of time". ■

–Amit Gurbaxani

CHORD CONNECTION
Chandavarkar and Taylor

